

30 Minutes Expert Virtual Desktops in Windows

With today's powerful computers and changing work scenario, you work with various applications simultaneously. This clutters the taskbar with many buttons and you end up wasting time switching between applications.

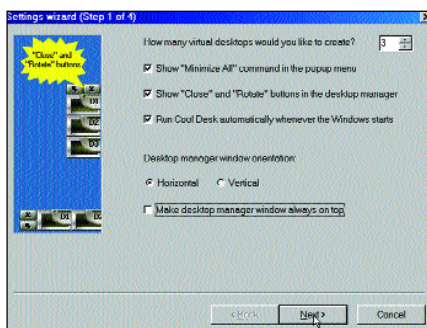
One easy solution to manage this clutter is using multiple desktops, or workspaces. Though Windows has only one desktop, there are certain utilities, called Virtual Desktop Managers that allow you to create multiple virtual desktops, thus allowing you to organise your work.

One such popular and powerful utility is Cool Desk. The latest version, 3.87, can be found on the Mindware CD, or can be downloaded from http://www.shelltoys.com/virtual_desktop. The Setup Wizard is simple with clear installation instructions—after it is complete, you are immediately taken to Settings Wizard. You can choose to create up to 9 virtual desktops. You can also choose to show functions such as, 'Minimize All', 'Rotate', 'Close', etc.

In the next step, you can choose to

have a separate wallpaper for each virtual desktop. You can also make your icon text background transparent in Windows 98, or ME. To do this, check the box 'Enable transparent background for icon text'.

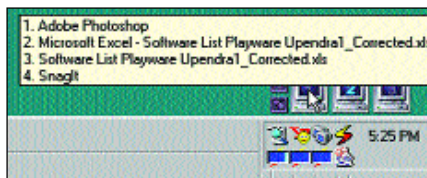
You can activate this wizard whenever you need it by going to **Start > Programs > Cool Desk > Settings Wizard**.



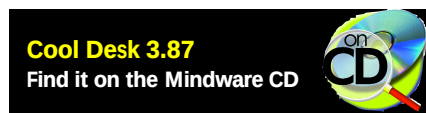
You can choose the level of customisation for your virtual desktops

Once you have completed the Settings Wizard, you will see the icons for the various desktops, on the desktop area and the Quick Launch toolbar. To jump to any virtual desktop, just click on its icon on the Quick Launch toolbar, or double-click the icon on the Windows desktop. You can also click on the Desktop Manager icon placed on the top-right corner of your screen. If you cannot see this, right-click on the Cool Desk icon in the System Tray and check Windows Manager. You can also use your scroll mouse to rotate between the various windows. You can configure this feature under Mouse tab in Settings.

Window Manager shows you the list of running programs on the active virtual desktop, as a drop-down list. When you want to see a comprehensive list move your mouse over the desktop icon on the

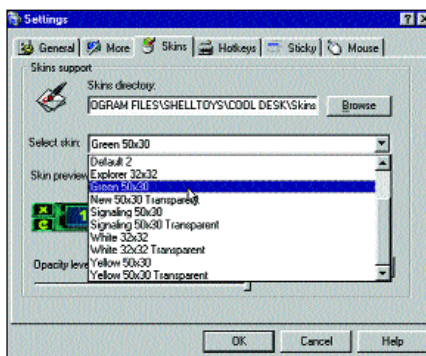


Desktop Manager gives you a list of programs running on each virtual desktop



Desktop Manager. This will show you the list of applications running on that virtual desktop as a tool tip.

Cool Desk offers you many options to customise it to your liking. For this, right-click on the Cool Desk icon, and go to **Settings > General**. Here, you will see all the options you saw in Settings Wizard. Under the More tab, you will find options



Give your Cool Desk the look you want

to enable own desktop icons, wallpaper and transparent background.

The default skin is Windows XP, but you can change it to one you like by going to the Skins tab in the Settings dialog box. Select the skin, see the preview and click OK to change the skin. You can download more skins from http://www.shelltoys.com/virtual_desktops/skins.html. If you are using Windows XP, you can also set the transparency level of the skin here.

Under the Hotkeys tab, you can assign shortcut key combinations for navigation. The default is **[Ctrl] + [Shift] + [desktop number]**. If you want certain applications to be shown on all the virtual desktops, you can list them out under the Sticky tab.

You can use other applications too (see box 'Other Options'), some are light and consume less memory, some are free and others have more features. ■

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Other Options

Desks At Will

This software from Idyle Software has many features that are exclusive to it, like placing pop ups in separate virtual desktops and placing specific applications in specific virtual desktops every time that application starts. You can create up to 10 virtual desktops in the Trial version. <http://www.idyle.com/software/utilities/desks-at-will/>

Perfect Screens

This utility allows you to have unlimited number of virtual screens. Some of the features of this utility, are application buttons specific to given virtual screen, screen exclusive windows and password protection. The interface is rich with buttons but it may take a while to understand it. <http://www.softwareutilities.com/psindex.htm>